

A couple of years ago Vicki and I happened upon a charming winery in the Andean foothills near Mendoza, a thousand miles or so from Buenos Aires. The owner, a second-generation German-Argentine, had inherited the winery from his father. His pride and joy, a full-bodied cabernet sauvignon, tasted like "poetry in a glass." I told him I liked it and asked where I could buy a couple of bottles in Buenos Aires.

He said, "I'd like to sell more in Buenos Aires. That's 90 percent of the market for quality wine in this country."

I pulled out a small notebook. "You've got a new customer. Give me the names of a couple of stores where I can buy it. Better yet, I'll call your distributor and order a couple of cases."

He shook his head. "I don't have a distributor. They want too much money. Better call me here and tell me what you want. I'll ship it to you."

Knowing the problems with telephones, I began to have doubts. But I decided to play along. "What's your phone number?"

He shook his head. "I don't have a phone. And mail doesn't always make it. Maybe you can call my son in Mendoza. He shares a phone with five other students. Sometimes I get through after only a couple of tries."

I said, "I'll take my chances on a letter. Shall I include a check with my order?"

He shook his head. "No checks. The bank won't cash a check. Besides, how would you know the price? With inflation the way it is I have to change my prices every week. A couple of weeks can go by before I get your order and ship it."

I said nothing. At this point I figured I had done my best. But I began to doubt that I would ever taste that wine again.

Finally the vintner brightened. "My brother lives in Buenos Aires. Maybe you could take the cash to him."

I said, "Maybe. But could you ship directly to my apartment? I don't have a car."